STATE SCAN

TAMIL NADU: BLOW BY BLOW ACCOUNTING PG 16
J&K: DRY RUN FOR FUTURE FAMINE PG 18



IN SOLIDARITY Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan with tribals in Kheoni Khurd village in Dewas, Jul. 5

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

A FIGHT IN THE FOREST

CM Mohan Yadav's pro-conservation policies run smack into a pro-people protest from his predecessor, Shivraj

By **Rahul Noronha**

IT'S DIFFICULT AS IT IS TO ADJUDICATE between a 'pure' conservation approach and one sympathetic to human habitation in forest areas. In Madhya Pradesh, it was not made easier last week when politics entered the fray—with a relocated tiger, as it were, returning to stalk his old prey base. The first kill didn't take long, as Union agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan led a delegation of tribals from Vidisha, his Lok Sabha constituency, protesting removal of encroachments on forest land and plans to create a new wildlife sanctuary. Chief minister Mohan Yadav had to bite the bullet and transfer a forest officer.

THE WILD LIFE OF POLITICS

How did conservation become the battleground? Put it down to contrasting politics. Chouhan did not create a single new sanctuary over his 16 years as CM, but Yadav has built up a strikingly pro-conservation image over his 18 months, signing off on two new tiger reserves and a wildlife sanctuary pending for decades. That USP seems at risk of being undone by populism. What with the ex-CM returning to basics, leading agitations on behalf of affected communities, even launching